

LIVE

Learning Space

NEWSPAPER

2nd July, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

27th WEEK



SEYCHELLES VS MALDIVES

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations



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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

2nd JULY, 2018

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Seychelles template

Soft diplomacy in the Indian Ocean Region
will serve India better

New Delhi has clearly opted for a charm offensive in the Indian Ocean Region (IOR). The red carpet laid out for the visiting Seychelles President Danny Faure last week came against the backdrop of setbacks in the bilateral relationship owing to the Assumption Island agreement being put on hold. The pact, to build a naval base on the island, was seen as a major strategic enhancement of India's IOR naval capacities and had been under discussion since 2003. It was finally signed during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to the Seychelles in 2015. The deal was to include 30-year access to the base as well as permission to station Indian military personnel on the ground, with facilities on the island funded by India, owned by Seychelles and jointly managed. After Opposition protests about loss of sovereignty, however, it had to be renegotiated and an amended version was signed in January 2018. Even that proved insufficient. Mr. Faure lacks the numbers in the legislature to ratify it, and with the Opposition sticking to its stand he announced in early June he would not be taking the agreement with India forward. Instead, Seychelles would build the naval facility "on its own". Given the blow to India's plan, Mr. Faure may well have expected a cold reception in India. However, both sides decided to walk around the minefields relating to Assumption Island, with Mr. Modi saying they would work on the project "keeping in mind each other's interests". India also announced a credit line of \$100 million for Seychelles to purchase defence equipment from India to build its maritime capacity, offered to finance civilian infrastructure including the official buildings, and handed over a Dornier aircraft for maritime surveillance purposes.

This is good strategy. It would have been pointless to push the Seychelles President for a more concrete assurance on the Assumption Island project, as he has little room for manoeuvre. India had earlier drawn a blank in attempting to negotiate directly with the Seychelles Opposition leader, Wavel Ramkalawan, who is of Indian origin. Until 2020-21, when Seychelles is due for presidential and parliamentary elections, it may not be possible to move the agreement further for ratification; rather than renegotiate or cancel it entirely, it is best to keep it in abeyance. This softer approach adopted by the government is in remarkable contrast to the strong-arm tactics it has used in the past with other countries in the IOR, such as the Maldives. India's very public statements against the Abdulla Yameen government have now led to a considerable setback to its strategic position there, with the Maldives insisting on sending back Indian naval and coast guard helicopters from its atolls. A less confrontational approach in the case of Seychelles, with quiet negotiations instead of public re-priming, indeed appears to have had a more salutary effect.

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3 Seychelles template

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UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations

Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and / or affecting India's interests.

IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

India's dealing of foreign relations in Maldives issue and Seychelles issue presents quite a contrast situation. Discuss.





Assumption Island

Agalega island
Mauritius

Sabang Port

Sumatra island

Indian
Ocean



SAGA OF SEYCHELLES NAVAL BASE

- 1** The Pact, to build a naval base on Assumption island, was seen as a major strategic enhancement of India's Indian Ocean Region naval capacities and It is under discussion since 2003.
- 2** It was finally agreed during Indian Prime Minister's visit to the Seychelles in 2015.
- 3** It is to include 30-year access to the base as well as permission to station Indian military personnel on the ground, with facilities funded by India, owned by Seychelles and jointly managed.



SAGA OF SEYCHELLES NAVAL BASE

- 4 However, Opposition protested about loss of sovereignty. It had to be renegotiated and amended version was signed in January 2018.
- 5 In June, because of the Opposition protests, the Seychelles Government stated that it would not be taking the agreement with India forward, instead Seychelles would built the naval facility on its own.

IN SPITE OF THIS, INDIA HAS GIVEN WARM RECEPTION TO SEYCHELLES PRESIDENT



India knows the fact that until 2021, when Seychelles is due for presidential and parliamentary elections, nothing much can be done and hence. India felt that rather than renegotiating or cancelling it entirely, it is best to keep it in abeyance and this is the softer approach adopted by India.

- 1 Indian Prime Minister said that they would work on the project keeping in mind each other's interests.
- 2 India also announced a credit line of \$ 100 million for Seychelles to purchase defence equipment from India to build its maritime capacity.
- 3 India offered to finance civilian infrastructure, including the official buildings.
- 4 India also handed over a Dornier aircraft for maritime surveillance purposes.



ABDULLA YAMEEN
President, Maldives



SEE THE QUIET CONTRAST APPROACH TOWARDS MALDIVES!

- 1** India's public statements against the Abdulla Yameen Government led to a considerable setback to its strategic position.
- 2** Now, Maldives insists on sending back Indian naval and coast guard helicopters from its atolls.

Less confrontational approach in the case of Seychelles, with quiet negotiations instead of public recrimination, appears to have had a more salutary effect.

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